Curriculum and App Flow: Stations 1 to 4

Locked designs for the MVP, as of 26 October 2026

1. The idea in one paragraph

The app teaches music production to complete beginners by letting them rebuild one track. In onboarding the user hears a finished track, then it strips down to a bare pulse. In each lesson one layer of that track breaks, the lesson teaches a skill that works on any track, and the user earns the control or sound that fixes it. Challenges and musician points are designed separately (see Open items). Four stations (drums, harmony, bass and melody, arrangement) hold 12 lessons and 4 finales. Stations 1 to 3 are open from the start, and Station 4 opens when any two stations are complete.

2. App flow

1. **Onboarding.** Cold open: a slow kick at 60 BPM, a pulsing ring and a haptic tap on every beat. The reveal: the finished track plays for about 30 seconds and each layer lights its object in the room. The strip-down: layers drop out until only the pulse is left, with covers over the keyboard and the synth. One question: “Have you made music before?” Never starts the guided run. A little and I make beats open the room with everything available.
2. **Guided first run (about 10 minutes, “Never” only).** Only the drum kit is lit. The user does 1.1 Tempo and Beats, finishes with “Tune the track”, then does 1.2 Drum Roles. The covers then lift and the room opens.
3. **The room (Learn tab).** A first-person view of a producer’s table: a drum kit (Station 1), a piano or keys (Station 2), a synth (Station 3) and a monitor showing the track’s lanes (Station 4 and the track itself). There are two ways in: tap an object to see its three lessons and finale, or tap a broken lane on the monitor to open the lesson that fixes it. Each object has three states: locked, in progress, complete.
4. **Lesson anatomy.** Hear it perfect (the track plays right), then it breaks (a fixed, audible fault in one layer), then Learn (the principle, in general terms), then Do (guided practice, on the track or on practice material), then Earn (the control or sound that fixes the track, and the track gets a rough patch). After a lesson the user chooses Next lesson or Back to the room.
5. **Station finale.** After the three lessons the user builds that layer of the track with earned sounds. The take replaces the rough patch and the room object turns complete.
6. **Sandbox and Profile.** The Sandbox starts with a free starter kit (it includes a kick) and adds earned sounds, and the main track opens there as a project. Profile shows the sound collection and studio days.

	What you do	Help	Question it answers
Learn	Listen and explore 2 or 3 short cards. Nothing is scored.	Full: the idea is explained	What is it, and why does it work?

	What you do	Help	Question it answers
Do	Apply it step by step with the app watching	Cues, hints, instant feedback, unlimited retries	Can I do it with support?

3. Rules for every lesson

- **Any-song rule.** Every lesson's skill is stated as a sentence a user could apply to any track. The main track is where each lesson starts (hear it perfect, then hear it break) and where it ends (the fix, a rough patch and the finale). Do steps can run on any practice material, so the skill carries beyond one track.
- **Screen layout for Do steps.** The track monitor on top, one prompt line, and the interaction at the bottom. Tap targets are at least 44pt.
- **Feedback.** A tapped note or pad sounds instantly. Correct turns solid with a soft tick. Wrong flashes red with a one-line reason, and nothing resets.
- **Hints.** After 2 misses on one item the step shows its hint, and after 3 it shows the answer and moves on (it counts as a miss). Steps repeat without limit. A few Do steps give a hint earlier, after one miss, and say so.
- **Timing.** A tap counts as in time within ±100ms unless the lesson says otherwise.
- **Sounds.** Practice sounds come from a generic built-in kit. Earned sounds are the ones in your collection, the main track and the Sandbox. Every clip is note data played by in-app voices, so there are no audio files to license.
- **Tap strength.** iPhones can't sense pressure, so drum pads use tap position: the centre is loud and the edge is soft, with a matching haptic and ripple. Drag-to-edit is the accessible alternative.
- **Pads.** Note pads show only the key's notes (8 pads: the seven notes plus the home note again), and the bass voice plays one octave lower. Chord pads show the key's 7 chords.
- **Fallbacks.** A layer the user hasn't built plays its ghost or rough patch, so a lesson never stalls.
- **Scripted breaks.** Every break is a fixed version of the track, the same for every user, so the stations stay independent. The user's own takes replace a lane only at the finale.
- **Earned controls.** During a lesson its control is available inside the practice screen. Earning it unlocks the control on the main track and in the Sandbox.
- **Names.** "Station", "Lesson" and "studio days" are proposals that haven't been confirmed.

4. The main track, what breaks and what each lesson earns (subject to change)

Provisional track (replace after the track brief): A minor, 100 BPM, 4/4, a chill hip-hop feel with light swing, chords Am, F, C, G (the "Epic" 1–6–3–7 pattern), the kick on beats 1 and 3, and the snare on beats 2 and 4.

Lesson	Hear it perfect	What breaks	Concept	Earns
1.1 Tempo and Beats	The full drum layer at the right tempo (about 100 BPM)	It drags to a slow, dull crawl	Pulse, beat 1, BPM, energy bands	Tempo control, which sets the track back to its real BPM
1.2 Drum Roles	The full beat with kick, snare and hi-hat	The snare and hi-hat drop out, leaving a bare kick	Three jobs: kick (weight), snare (backbeat), hi-hat (clock)	Snare and hi-hat
1.3 Groove	The full beat, with a human feel	It goes stiff and robotic: everything on the grid, all at the same volume	Quantise, swing, accents, percussion in the gaps	Quantise and swing controls, plus clap, shaker and rim sounds
1.4 Drum Take (finale)	An empty drum lane	The lane is empty	Everything from 1.1 to 1.3	The user's drum take, which replaces the rough patch
2.1 Scales, Root Notes and Keys	The harmony under the drums, settled and pleasant	Single notes wander, each bar from a random key: sour and lost	Home note, major or minor, key	Key lock: the pads show only notes that fit A minor
2.2 Chords and Moods	The full harmony	It shrinks to one bare held note, so it sounds hollow	A chord is notes together; bright, dark or tense; a key has 7 chords	4 pads (yet to decide which 4 depending on key)
2.3 Chord Progressions	The 4-chord loop (Am, F, C, G)	Real chords play, but the same chord repeats every bar	Chord 1 is home, loops of 4, numbers work in any key	All 7 chords in the decided key
2.4 Harmony Take (finale)	An empty harmony lane	The lane is empty	Everything from 2.1 to 2.3	The user's harmony take, which replaces the rough patch

3.1 Basslines and Kick Interlock	Drums, chords and bass locked together	The bass drops out and the low end vanishes, so the track sounds thin	The bass role; together or taking turns with the kick	The bass pads (one octave lower, the lit pad follows the chords)
3.2 Building a Hook	A short, hummable lead on top	The lead plays one flat note on every beat, like a beep	Safe notes, rhythm, shape	Some lead sound and the Go pentatonic toggle (5 safe notes)
3.3 Melodic Phrasing	A call and an answer that ends on home	The hook runs nonstop with no gaps and never finishes	Call and answer, repeat with a change, rests, end on home	Another lead sound
3.4 Bass and Melody Take (finale)	Two empty lanes	Both lanes are empty	Everything from 3.1 to 3.3	The user's bass and lead takes, which replace the rough patches
4.1 Song Sections	The full 32-bar song with its sections	All four layers play the same 4 bars for 32 bars: one loop, nothing happens	Sections have jobs, layers make sections, choruses repeat	The arrangement board (8 blocks, layer toggles, copy a section) and the Crash that marks section starts
4.2 Energy	A song that builds and releases and peaks in the last chorus	The shape is backwards: big at the start, a drop in the middle, a thin ending	Build, release, contrast	Volume and mute controls
4.3 Transitions	Sections glued smoothly together	Hard cuts between sections	Fill, riser, silence, hit	The Riser
4.4 Arrangement Take (finale)	An empty board	The board is empty	Everything from 4.1 to 4.3	The room plays the finished track from start to finish

What the main track must contain, worked out from the lessons above (replace after the track brief):

- **Tempo and key.** About 100 BPM in A minor, with chords Am, F, C and G. 100 BPM sits in the groove band, so the slow break in 1.1 is clearly out of band.
- **Drums with clear jobs.** Kick on beats 1 and 3, snare on 2 and 4 and a steady hi-hat, each on its own lane, so each job is audible when it drops out in 1.2. The kick stays sparse so both bass patterns work in 3.1.
- **A groove that can be removed.** Light swing, varied hi-hat accents and a small percussion layer, so the stiff version in 1.3 sounds clearly worse. One fill in the last beat of a bar.
- **Separate lanes.** Drums, harmony, bass and lead each mute on their own, because every break removes or damages one lane.
- **A hook on the pentatonic notes.** A, C, D, E and G only, with a 4-bar call and answer that ends on A and has at least one rest.
- **A real build.** Intro with 1 or 2 layers, Verses with 2 or 3, Choruses with all 4, a thin Breakdown, and a last Chorus that is the biggest moment, so the break in 4.2 is audible.
- **Placeholders.** Any layer the user hasn't built yet plays as a ghost or a labelled placeholder.

5. Dependencies

Stations 1, 2 and 3 are open from the start. Station 4 unlocks when any two stations are complete (a station is complete when its finale is done), and its finale needs all three station finales. Inside a station there are no hard locks: a check is a 15-second test at the start of a lesson, and a miss shows a short primer or offers the earlier lesson. Soft means a one-line refresher and no test.

Lesson	Needs	How it is checked	What it uses on the track
1.1 Tempo and Beats	Nothing	None	The slow-tempo break
1.2 Drum Roles	1.1 (soft)	One-line refresher	The bare-kick beat
1.3 Groove	1.2 (soft)	One-line refresher	The drum lane
1.4 Drum Take	1.1 to 1.3	Unlocks after the three lessons	The drum lane
2.1 Scales, Root Notes and Keys	Nothing	None	The harmony lane, and it locks the track's key
2.2 Chords and Moods	2.1	Check: tap the home note of a loop (a miss offers 2.1)	The harmony lane holds Am
2.3 Chord Progressions	2.2	Check: tap Bright or Dark for a chord (a miss offers 2.2)	The harmony lane gets the loop
2.4 Harmony Take	2.1 to 2.3	Unlocks after the three lessons	The harmony lane
3.1 Basslines and Kick Interlock	What a kick does, and a chord loop so	Check: tap the grid slot where the kick first hits (a miss shows a short primer on the kick)	Drums and harmony play underneath, and it fills the bass lane

Lesson	Needs	How it is checked	What it uses on the track
	the lit pad follows the chords		
3.2 Building a Hook	The home note	Check: tap the home note pad (a miss shows a short primer on the home note)	Drums, chords and bass play underneath, and it fills the lead lane
3.3 Melodic Phrasing	The home note, and 3.2 (your kept hook is the call, with a ghost call if there is none)	Check: play any 3 pads, then tap the one that feels like home (a miss shows a short primer on the home note)	Drums, chords, bass and the call play underneath
3.4 Bass and Melody Take	3.1 to 3.3	Unlocks after the three lessons	The bass and lead lanes
4.1 Song Sections	Station 4 open (any two stations complete), with placeholders for unfinished stations	Check: tap the lane that isn't playing (a miss offers the matching lesson from Stations 1 to 3)	All four lanes
4.2 Energy	4.1 (soft)	One-line refresher	The arrangement
4.3 Transitions	4.1 (soft)	One-line refresher	The arrangement
4.4 Arrangement Take	4.1 to 4.3, and the finales of Stations 1 to 3	Unlocks after the three lessons and all three station finales	The whole track

Dependency map

- **Starting points.** Stations 1, 2 and 3 are open from the start, so a user can begin in drums, harmony or bass and melody.
- **Station 1:** 1.1, then 1.2, then 1.3, then the Drum Take.
- **Station 2:** 2.1, then 2.2, then 2.3, then the Harmony Take.
- **Station 3:** 3.1 checks what a kick does and uses a chord loop (the default progression plays if Station 2 isn't done). 3.2 checks the home note. 3.3 checks the home note and uses the hook from 3.2 (a ghost call plays if there is none). All three lead to the Bass and Melody Take. A missed check shows a 30-second primer inside the lesson, with a link to the earlier lesson.

- **Station 4:** opens when any two stations are complete, and a station is complete when its finale is done. Layers from a station not yet finished appear as labelled placeholders, so the exercises still work. 4.1 comes first, then 4.2 and 4.3, then the Arrangement Take, which needs all three station finales.
- **Sounds** are not needed to do any lesson, because practice uses a built-in kit. They matter for the finales and the Sandbox.

6. Station 1: Drums (Module 1)

Room object: the drum kit. Status: locked.

1.1 Tempo and Beats (about 5 minutes)

Skill: count the pulse in 4s and pick a tempo that matches the energy you want.

Break: the drum layer plays at the right tempo (about 100 BPM), then it drags to a slow, dull crawl.

Learn (3 cards):

- Music is a steady pulse grouped into bars of 4, and beat 1 feels strongest.
- BPM is beats per minute, and faster means more energy.
- Rough energy bands: 60 to 90 laid-back, 90 to 110 groove, 120 to 130 dance, 140 and up high energy. Each plays the same beat in that band.

Do:

- Tap the pulse along with 3 short clips in different styles. A ring shows early or late. Pass: 6 of 8 taps within ±80ms per clip.
- Find the 1: tap only beat 1 for 4 bars. Round 1 is four-on-the-floor with a cue (a crash or bass note on each 1), because the kick hits every beat and can't show where 1 is. Round 2 is a sparse hip-hop beat (kick on 1 and the "&" of 3, snare on 2 and 4) with no cue.
- Match the brief: one dial sets the tempo of a fixed beat. The briefs are "workout" and "late-night". Pass: each lands in the right band.
- Tune the track: the user taps along with the broken drum layer, names its energy band, then sets the tempo control back to the track's real tempo (within ±5 BPM). A wrong band gets one retry, then the track snaps to its real tempo with an explanation.

Earn: the tempo control. The drum layer plays at its real tempo again.

Needs: nothing.

1.2 Drum Roles (about 7 minutes)

Skill: every beat is three jobs on a grid: weight, backbeat and clock.

Break: the full beat plays with kick, snare and hi-hat, then the snare and hi-hat drop out and only a bare kick is left.

Learn (3 cards):

- The kick is low and marks the beat, the snare is the crack on 2 and 4 (the backbeat), and the hi-hat is high and divides time.
- A bar is a grid of 8 slots, and a pattern is a choice of which slots to hit.
- The same jobs make different patterns, such as a backbeat beat (kick on 1 and 3) and four-on-the-floor (kick on every beat).

Do:

- Name the job: 6 rounds of single hits from different kits (acoustic, 808, house), tapping Weight, Backbeat or Clock. Pass: 5 of 6.
- Build a backbeat in 3 passes (kick, snare, hat) at a tempo you choose. Pass: 75% of hits in the right slots within ±100ms.
- Convert it to four-on-the-floor by moving only the kicks.

Earn: snare and hi-hat. The full beat comes back on the track.

Needs: 1.1 (soft).

1.3 Groove (about 6 minutes)

Skill: control how tight, swung and dynamic a beat is, so it feels played by a person.

Break: the full beat plays with a human feel, then it goes stiff and robotic: everything on the grid, all at the same volume. You hear “machine” next to “human”.

Learn (3 cards, in this order):

- Quantise snaps hits to the grid, from 0% (raw) to 100% (exact). Too loose sounds sloppy and too tight sounds robotic.
- Swing delays the off-beats. 50% is straight and 55 to 60% is laid-back.
- Accents and percussion: some hits are loud and some are soft, and percussion (shaker, rim, clap, tom) lives in the gaps and in the last beat of a bar as a small fill.

Do (on the drum pad, where the centre is loud and the edge is soft):

- Tighten: a sloppy loop (about ±70ms error) with a quantise knob and a live timing readout. Pass: average error under 25ms at a strength below 100%.
- Swing: A/B against a reference loop and set the slider within ±4%.
- Accents and percussion, in three small tasks: hats loud on the beats and soft on the “&”s (6 of 8 slots right), shaker or rim hits in empty slots (at least one soft and one loud), and a 2-hit tom or clap fill in the last beat of bar 2.

Earn: the quantise and swing controls, and the clap, shaker and rim sounds. The track plays the humanised beat.

Needs: 1.2 (soft).

1.4 Finale: Drum Take (about 5 minutes)

Unlocks after 1.1 to 1.3. Build a 4-bar drum layer with the earned sounds and a quiet click. **Pass:** kick, snare and hat present; snare on 2 and 4 in at least 3 of 4 bars; quantise and swing set deliberately; at least 2 accented percussion hits from the earned kit; and a percussion fill in the last beat of bar 4. **Result:** the take replaces the rough patch and the drum kit turns complete.

7. Station 2: Harmony (Module 2)

Room object: the piano or keys. Status: locked. Practice sounds are a generic piano and pad.

2.1 Scales, Root Notes and Keys (about 6 minutes)

Skill: every song has a home note and a mood, major or minor. Together they make its key, and the key's notes fit together.

Break: the harmony plays settled and pleasant under the drums, then it breaks: single notes wander, each bar from a random key, and it sounds sour and lost.

Learn (3 cards):

- Every tune has a home note. A tune that ends on it feels finished, and one that ends elsewhere hangs.
- Major is bright and minor is dark ("Major · happy" and "Minor · sad", with the text "usually").
- Home note plus mood makes the key. The key's 7 notes are tinted, the others clash, and the Sandbox asks for the home note and the mood when you start a project.

Do:

- Find the track's home note: the ghost hook loops over your drums, and you tap Lock in on the note it settles on (hint: a drone on the root). Pass: A.
- Happy or sad: 10 rounds in three stages (the same tune flipped, with a "Hear the other one" button; new tunes on different sounds; busier clips at 120 BPM). After every answer the other version plays so you hear the contrast. Pass: 8 of 10. Round 11 plays the track's hook, and you choose Major or Minor. The monitor then reads "A minor, key locked" (one retry, then the answer is shown).
- Spot the odd notes: 3 loops, each with 8 note blocks and 2 off notes. Tap them, then Check. Loop 1 is the track's own harmony lane, which is corrected afterwards. Pass: 2 of 3 loops with both found and at most 1 false flag.

Earn: key lock. The pads show only the notes that fit A minor, and the track's key locks to A minor.

Needs: nothing.

2.2 Chords and Moods (about 5 minutes)

Check (15s): tap the home note of a loop. A miss offers 2.1.

Skill: chords have moods too. A key gives you 7 pads that always fit, and each pad is bright, dark or tense.

Break: the full harmony plays, then it shrinks to one bare held note and sounds hollow.

Learn (3 cards):

- A chord is notes played together (A, C and E).
- Chords are bright (major) or dark (minor).
- A key comes with 7 pads (in A minor: Am, B dim, C, Dm, Em, F, G), each marked bright, dark or tense. They are the same pads as in the Sandbox, and an "outsider" chord shows a clash.

Do:

- Bright or dark: single chords on different roots and sounds, and after each answer the other version plays. Stage 1 (4 rounds) has "Hear the other one" and stage 2 (4 rounds) doesn't. Pass: 6 of 8.
- Odd chord out: 6 four-chord loops (3 in A minor, 3 in other keys), each with one chord outside the key. Tap it, then Check. Pass: 4 of 6.

Earn: the 7 chord pads and the Keys sound. The track's harmony lane holds Am as a full chord across 4 bars.

Needs: 2.1 (check).

2.3 Chord Progressions (about 6 minutes)

Check (15s): a chord plays and you tap Bright or Dark. A miss offers 2.2.

Skill: most songs loop 4 chords. Chord 1 is home, ending on any other chord makes the loop turn around, and the order sets the feel.

Break: the 4-chord loop (Am, F, C, G) plays, then it breaks: real chords play, but the same chord repeats every bar and the loop goes nowhere.

Learn (3 cards):

- Chord 1 is home. A loop that lands on it arrives, and one that stops early hangs.
- Most songs loop 4 chords: Sunny (1–5–6–4 in C major), Epic (1–6–3–7 in A minor) and Falling (1–7–6–5 in A minor).
- Numbers work in any key (A minor, D minor, G major).

Do:

- Arrive or hang: 6 loops, tapping Arrived or Hanging (arrived means it ended on chord 1). Pass: 5 of 6.
- Build the track's loop: drag pads 1, 6, 3 and 7 into the four bar slots (Epic in A minor: Am, F, C, G), or try Falling, then Keep one. Pass: Epic built and one kept. The kept loop fills the lane.
- Fix the stuck loop: a C major loop (C, Am, F, C) feels stuck at the turnaround, so change bar 4 to any other pad. Pass: bar 4 isn't chord 1.

Earn: the four chord slots (drag pads into the bars) and the Pad and Chord stab sounds. The kept loop plays on the Pad.

Needs: 2.2 (check).

2.4 Finale: Harmony Take (about 6 minutes)

Unlocks after 2.1 to 2.3. Drag a chord into each of 4 bars, then choose a sound (Pad, Keys or Stab) and a rhythm (Hold, 2 hits or 4 hits) for each bar. **Pass:** bar 1 is chord 1, bar 4 isn't, at least 3 different chords, at least 2 earned sounds used, and at least one bar not on Hold. **Result:** the take replaces the lane, the piano turns complete, and the track plays 8 bars with drums and harmony.

8. Station 3: Bass and Melody (Module 3)

Room object: the synth. Status: locked. Note pads show only the key's notes (8 pads in a 4×2 grid), and the bass voice plays one octave lower.

3.1 Basslines and Kick Interlock (about 6 minutes)

Check (15s): a drum loop plays. Tap the grid slot where the kick first hits. A miss shows a 30-second primer on what the kick does, with a link to 1.2.

Skill: look at the kick pattern, then choose how the bass shares the low end: together, taking turns, long notes or a steady pulse.

Break: drums, chords and bass play locked together, then the bass drops out and the low end vanishes, so the track sounds thin.

Learn (3 cards):

- What bass is and why you need it: "With bass" and "Without bass" play the same 2 bars. Bass is the lowest part of a track, you feel it as much as you hear it, and it gives the track weight and joins the drums to the chords.
- Kick and bass share the low end: a beat selector ("Sparse kick" on beats 1 and 3, or "Kick on every beat") with two buttons, Together (bass hits with the kick) and Taking turns (bass hits between the kicks). Together feels tight and punchy, and Taking turns leaves the kick clear and makes the groove bounce.
- Pick by the kick: the same selector with four chips. Together (hip-hop, trap), Taking turns (house, disco), Long notes (one note held per bar; ballads, ambient) and Steady pulse (a note on every

half-beat, whatever the kick does; pop, rock). Rule: sparse kick, play with it; kick on every beat, play between the kicks.

Do:

- Which pattern? A 4-bar loop plays and you tap Together, Taking turns, Long notes or Steady pulse. 8 rounds, 2 of each, mixed across both kinds of beat. A grid shows the hits after every answer. Hint after 2 wrong in a row: the grid shows live. Pass: 6 of 8.
- Play it on the track and on a new beat. The bass pad you need is lit and changes with the chords. Pass 1, on the track (kick on 1 and 3): tap the lit pad on each of the 8 kick-hit dots over 4 bars. Pass 2, on a practice house loop (kick on every beat): tap the lit pad on each of 8 faint slots between the kicks over 2 bars. Each pass needs 6 of 8 solid. Hint after a miss: the next slot pulses.

Earn: the bass pads (one octave lower, the lit pad follows the chords) and the Sub bass. The track's bass lane plays with the kick.

Needs: what a kick does (checked at the start; a miss shows a short primer), and a chord loop so the lit pad follows the chords (the default progression plays if 2.3 isn't done).

3.2 Building a Hook (about 6 minutes)

Check (15s): tap the home note pad of a loop. A miss shows a 30-second primer on the home note, with a link to 2.1.

Skill: a hook is a short, repeatable melody. Build it from safe notes, a clear rhythm and a simple shape.

Break: a short, hummable lead plays on top, then the lead breaks into one flat note on every beat, like a beep.

Learn (3 cards):

- Start with safe notes: the 7 pads for A minor over the chord loop, with B and F pulsing because they sound tense against some chords. "Go pentatonic" dims them and leaves A, C, D, E and G, five notes with no clashes.
- Rhythm makes the tune: the same 4 notes play in a Steady rhythm and a Bouncy rhythm, with the hits shown on an 8-slot grid. The same notes can sound totally different.
- Shape makes it catchy: Up, Down and Wave chips each play a 4-note hook and draw its shape over the pads, and a Small range or Wide range toggle plays the same shape over 3 pads or all 5. Hooks usually follow a simple shape and stay in a small range.

Do:

- Tap the rhythm: a 1-bar rhythm plays twice with its 4 hits lighting on the grid, then you tap it back for 2 loops (8 taps). Steady is slots 1, 3, 5, 7, Bouncy A is 1, 4, 5, 7 and Bouncy B is 1, 3, 6, 7. Hint after one miss: the dots light again. Pass: 6 of 8 taps in time on 2 of 3 rhythms.

- Echo the riff: the pads show only the 5 lit notes, a 4-note riff plays and the pads light in order, and you tap the same pads (the order counts, not the timing). Three riffs: Up, Down and Wave, and the app names each shape. Hint after one wrong tap: the riff replays with the pads lit. Pass: 2 of 3.
- Build your hook on the track: the track loops with drums, chords and bass, and a prompt line says “Hum a tune over the loop first, then find it on the pads.” Pick a rhythm chip (Steady, Bouncy A or Bouncy B), tap Record and play it on the lit pads for 2 bars. A checklist ticks live: all notes on lit pads, the chosen rhythm in both bars (6 of 8 hits in time), and 4 or fewer different pads. Tap Keep when all three are ticked. Hint after 2 failed tries: the rhythm’s dots pulse and the unticked item shows a tip.

Earn: the Pluck lead voice and the Go pentatonic toggle (the 5 safe notes). The track’s lead lane plays your kept hook. Then a “Tips for your next hook” card appears (one scrollable card with a Got it button):

1. Hum it first. Hum or sing over your loop before you touch the pads, then find those notes.
2. Keep it short and simple: 2 bars, 3 to 5 notes per bar.
3. Start with one note. If you’re stuck, play one pad in a rhythm and add a second note later.
4. Stay in a small range: stick to 3 or 4 pads, because big jumps are hard to hum.
5. Borrow the drums’ rhythm: copy the kick or snare rhythm, or play in the gaps between them.
6. Do the next-day test: if you can still hum it tomorrow without the app, it’s a hook.

Needs: the home note (checked at the start; a miss shows a short primer, with a link to 2.1).

3.3 Melodic Phrasing (about 6 minutes)

Check (15s): play any 3 pads, then tap the one that feels like home. A miss shows a 30-second primer on the home note, with a link to 2.1.

Skill: a melody talks in short phrases, a call and then an answer. Leave space, repeat with a small change, and end on the home note when you want it to feel finished.

Break: a call and an answer play and the melody ends on home, then the hook breaks into a nonstop run with no gaps that never finishes.

Learn (3 cards):

- Call and answer: a 4-bar melody with bars 1 and 2 as the call and bars 3 and 4 as the answer, with Play call, Play answer and Play both buttons. The call rises, and the answer falls and ends on the home note.
- Repeat, then change: the same 2-bar shape plays twice, as Repeat exactly or Repeat with one change (the changed note lights up the second time).
- Leave space and end home: a Wall of notes or With rests toggle, and an Ends on home or Ends elsewhere toggle. Rests let a melody breathe, and ending on home feels finished.

Do:

- Answer or hanging? A 2-bar call plays, then two possible answers, A and B. Tap the one that sounds finished. 6 rounds (2 in A minor, 4 in other keys), and both endings replay labelled after each answer. Hint after 2 wrong in a row: the home note pad lights. Pass: 5 of 6.
- Play the answer: the track loops with drums, chords, bass and the call (your hook from 3.2, or a ghost call) in bars 1 and 2. Record the answer in bars 3 and 4 on the lit pads. A checklist ticks live: ends on A, has a rest of at least one beat, and 3 to 6 notes. Tap Keep when all three are ticked. Hint after 2 failed tries: the unticked item pulses with a tip. Your call and answer become the track's melody.
- Repeat with a change (practice only, not kept): the call plays once, then you record it again changing 1 or 2 notes. A checklist ticks live: the same rhythm as the first time (at least 75% of hits within ±100ms) and 1 or 2 notes different. Hint after 2 failed tries: the changed notes show as dots on the pads.

Earn: the 4-bar phrase recorder (call and answer slots with a rest marker) and the Bell lead. The track's lead lane plays your call and answer.

Needs: the home note (checked at the start; a miss shows a short primer), and 3.2 (your kept hook is the call; a ghost call plays if there is none).

3.4 Finale: Bass and Melody Take (about 7 minutes)

Unlocks after 3.1 to 3.3. The track plays with drums and harmony, and you record two layers with the earned voices, bass first and then lead.

- **Bass:** 4 bars. Choose Together or Taking turns (both suit the track's beat). The right pad stays lit. Pass: at least 6 of 8 slots solid (the kick hits for Together, the gaps between kicks for Taking turns).
- **Lead:** a 4-bar phrase on the pentatonic pads, with a call in bars 1 and 2 and an answer in bars 3 and 4. Pass: all notes on lit pads, the answer ends on the home note, at least one rest, and the answer differs from the call by at least one note.
- **Result:** both takes replace the rough patches, the Bass and Melody lanes fill, and the synth in the room turns complete.

9. Station 4: Arrangement (Module 4)

Room object: the monitor. Status: locked until any two stations are complete. The Arrangement Board has 4 lanes (Drums, Harmony, Bass, Lead) and 8 blocks of 4 bars, which is 32 bars or about 77 seconds at 100 BPM. Tap a block to turn that layer on or off in that block, tap a block's header to play from there, and an energy meter above the board shows how many layers are on. The track's structure is Intro (block 1), Verse (2 and 3), Chorus (4 and 5), Breakdown (6) and Chorus (7 and 8). The blocks look like the Sandbox's pattern blocks, because users arrange in the Sandbox by positioning patterns on a timeline, like FL Studio.

4.1 Song Sections (about 7 minutes)

Check (15s): a 4-bar loop plays with three layers. Tap the lane that isn't playing. A miss offers the matching lesson from Stations 1 to 3.

Skill: a song is a few sections, each with a job. Turn layers on and off to change section.

Break: the full 32-bar song plays with its sections, then all four layers play the same 4 bars for 32 bars: one loop and nothing happens.

Learn (3 cards):

- Sections have jobs: Intro (sets the mood), Verse (tells the story), Chorus (the big part you remember) and Breakdown (a pause before the big return). Each chip plays 4 bars of the track in that role.
- Layers make sections: the board shows the track's sections with each section's layers lit, and an "All layers on" toggle plays the same 4 bars flat.
- Sections come in blocks and repeat: a bar counter runs as a section plays, and an animated finger drags the Chorus chip onto blocks 7 and 8. Sections usually last 4 or 8 bars, a new one starts on beat 1, and choruses repeat, so copy one instead of rebuilding it.

Do:

- Name the section: a 4-bar clip plays and you tap Intro, Verse, Chorus or Breakdown. 8 rounds, the first 4 from the track and the last 4 from other tracks. The board shows which layers were on after each answer. Hint after 2 wrong in a row: the board shows live. Pass: 6 of 8.
- Build the first six blocks: headers are pre-labelled for blocks 1 to 6 and blocks 7 and 8 are greyed out. Tap blocks to turn layers on. A checklist ticks live: Intro has 1 or 2 layers, each Verse has 2 or 3 layers, each Chorus has all 4, and the Breakdown has 2 or fewer layers and no Drums. Tap Keep when all four are ticked. Hint after 2 failed tries: the unticked item pulses with a tip.
- Repeat the chorus: the Chorus blocks show a drag handle (a chip labelled "Chorus"). Drag it onto blocks 7 and 8, and all 4 layers copy in (accessible alternative: long-press the chip, tap Copy to, and pick blocks 7 and 8). Hint after 2 misses: a finger animation shows the drag. Pass: blocks 7 and 8 match blocks 4 and 5 on all 4 layers. Your arrangement then plays as the track.

Earn: the arrangement board (8 blocks, layer toggles, copy a section) and the Crash that marks section starts. The track plays your 32-bar arrangement.

Needs: Station 4 open, meaning any two stations are complete. A station not yet finished plays as a labelled placeholder layer, so the lesson never stalls.

4.2 Energy (about 6 minutes)

Skill: energy is how big a track feels. Add layers to build it, take them away to release it, and save your biggest moment for the end.

Break: the song builds and releases and peaks in the last chorus, then the shape turns backwards: big at the start, a drop in the middle and a thin ending, so the last chorus is the quietest part.

Learn (3 cards):

- Energy is how big it feels: “Low energy (2 layers)” and “High energy (4 layers)” each play 4 bars with the meter moving.
- Build and release: the 8 blocks drawn as a curve, with Build adding one layer at a time and Release removing them.
- Contrast makes the big parts big: the same chorus plays after a full verse (flat) and after a thin breakdown (huge).

Do:

- Which is bigger? Two 4-bar clips, A then B, and you tap “A is bigger” or “B is bigger”. 6 rounds: 4 differ in layer count and 2 in how busy the drums are. The meter shows both after each answer. Hint after 2 wrong in a row: the meter shows live. Pass: 5 of 6.
- Shape the track’s energy: the backwards arrangement is on the board with the meter above it. Prompt: “Build to the last chorus.” A checklist ticks live: Verse 2 has more layers than Verse 1, the Breakdown has at least 2 fewer layers than the Choruses, and the final Chorus has all 4 layers. Tap Keep when all three are ticked. Hint after 2 failed tries: the unticked item pulses with a tip.

Earn: the energy meter and the Impact hit. The monitor shows your arrangement’s energy curve.

Needs: 4.1 (soft).

4.3 Transitions (about 6 minutes)

Skill: a transition marks the moment one section turns into the next. Put it in the last 1 or 2 bars before the change, and land it on beat 1.

Break: the sections glue smoothly together, then it breaks into hard cuts between sections with nothing between them.

Learn (3 cards):

- Transitions glue sections: “Cut” and “With transition” play the end of the Breakdown into the Chorus.
- Four tools: Fill (the drums get busier in the last beat), Riser (a sound that climbs and builds tension), Silence (everything stops for a beat) and Hit (a Crash or Impact on beat 1 of the new section).
- Where they go: a timeline of the last bar and beat 1 of the next section, with the Riser across the last 1 or 2 bars, Silence on the last beat and the Hit on beat 1.

Do:

- Which transition? The last 2 bars and beat 1 of a section change play, and you tap Fill, Riser, Silence or Hit. 8 rounds, 2 per tool. The timeline shows the tool after each answer. Hint after 2 wrong in a row: the timeline shows live. Pass: 6 of 8.

- Add the glue on the track: the board shows 3 transition slots (before Chorus 1, before the Breakdown and before the final Chorus), and a tray holds Fill, Riser, Silence, Crash and Impact. Drag a tool onto a slot and the 2 bars around it play. Drag a placed tool off the board to remove it (accessible alternative: tap a tool, then tap a slot). A checklist ticks live: all 3 slots filled, at least 2 different tools used, and a Riser or Silence before the final Chorus. Tap Keep when all three are ticked. Hint after 2 failed tries: the unticked item pulses with a tip.

Earn: the three transition slots and the Riser. The track plays your transitions.

Needs: 4.1 (soft).

4.4 Finale: Arrangement Take (about 7 minutes)

Unlocks after 4.1 to 4.3 and the finales of Stations 1 to 3. The board shows all 8 blocks and the 3 transition slots. Toggle to build layers, and drag to copy sections and place transitions. **Pass:** the section rules from 4.1, Verse 2 bigger than Verse 1, the final Chorus the highest, the Breakdown at least 2 layers below the Choruses, all 3 slots filled with at least 2 tools, and a Riser or Silence before the final Chorus. **Result:** the room plays your finished track from start to finish with every object lit.

10. Sandbox features the lessons assume

- A new project asks for the home note and the mood (major or minor), and the key locks.
- Chord pads show the key's 7 chords.
- Note pads show only the key's notes (8 pads). A "Go pentatonic" toggle that dims 2 pads is new.
- A Tips button on the melody pads that reopens the hook tips is optional and new.
- A looper with quantise and swing, and drum pads where tap position sets loudness.
- A timeline where patterns are positioned and dragged, like FL Studio. The lesson board uses the same block look.
- A free starter kit (it includes a kick) plus earned sounds, and the main track opens as a project.

11. Open items

1. **Battle Room and points.** Challenges are no longer part of this document. They move to a separate Battle Room, where challenges earn musician points. What the points cost, what they unlock (extra sounds, Sandbox templates, keys and scales) and how repeats are limited are not yet decided.
2. **Track brief.** Genre, tempo, key, and what the track sounds like at the start and when finished. The values in this document are provisional.
3. **Names.** "Station", "Lesson" and "studio days" are unconfirmed, and the sound collection has no name yet.

4. **Sound sourcing.** About 14 earned sounds plus the starter kit, made in-app or recorded. FL Studio's licence doesn't clearly allow bundling its sounds in an app, so ask Image-Line in writing before relying on them.
5. **Audio workload.** Every ear drill needs short clips, all as note data (for example, one tune written once and flipped between major and minor).
6. **Teaching simplification.** "Major is happy, minor is sad" is a rule of thumb. Teach the exceptions in v2.

Challenge:

Lesson 1.1:

1) **Hold the Beat** (from tap the pulse). A beat plays for 4 bars, then the sound drops out and the screen goes dark. Keep tapping the pulse, then the beat comes back and shows how far you drifted. Round 1 is 80 BPM with a 2-bar gap, round 2 is 124 BPM with a 4-bar gap, and round 3 is 140 BPM. Stars by drift in your tapped tempo: 3% or less is 3 stars, 6% or less is 2, and 10% or less is 1.
2) **Downbeat Dash** (from find the 1). A beat loops with no cue. Tap only the 1 of each bar, and every bar you land builds a combo that a miss resets. Round 1 is four-on-the-floor, round 2 a sparse hip-hop beat, and round 3 a syncopated beat where the kick isn't on the 1. 8 bars per round. Stars by bars right out of 24: 20 or more is 3 stars, 16 or more is 2, and 12 or more is 1.
3) **Band Sort** (from match the brief and the energy bands). Clips play for 6 seconds each as cards, and you swipe each into one of four bins (Laid-back, Groove, Dance, High energy). 6 clips, with the trickiest ones near the band edges in round 3.
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